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TOMORROW'S CHILD

**Screen-Smart
Summer**

**Crafting Confidence
with a Montessori
Woodworking
Program**

**Forged in Boredom:
Skills for a Lifetime**





TOMORROW'S CHILD

The International Magazine for Montessori Families

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CRAFTING CONFIDENCE, PG.12



AMAZING, BIZARRE, BEAUTIFUL



How modern brain science and the century-old wisdom of Marie Montessori can help new parents understand the amazing, bizarre, beautiful brains of their young children.

by Sandra Karnstadt, M.Ed. and Joshua Dodds, D.L.S.

AMAZING

The absorbent mind is indeed a marvelous gift to humanity! By merely 'living' and without any conscious effort the individual absorbs from the environment even a complex cultural achievement like language. How much easier our studies would be if this essential mental form existed in adults.
—Maria Montessori

Young children move through their environment very differently than adults, and this can create stressful, confusing situations for new parents. Montessori argued that because children's brains are absorbent and not rational, the environment surrounding a young child is not just a place. From a child's point of view, the environment acts as an invisible and influential teacher. It speaks to them without words, helps them discover who they are.

And while the absorbent minds of young children sometimes throw a wrench in the rational plans of adults, it is important for new parents to understand that this natural ability to absorb the world around them is one of the young child's most amazing superpowers.

The young child does not simply remember aspects of their environment or learn from them, they incorporate aspects of their surroundings into themselves. This process, Montessori claimed, is nothing less than the way that a person builds themselves from the inside out. Interestingly, modern science agrees.

Recent studies have demonstrated that the environment surrounding a child influences the physical structure of their brain. However researchers at Harvard's Center on the Developing Child have also demonstrated that young children are in what Montessori called a "sensitive period" for this type of brain plasticity in the first several years of life. This means that the superpower young children have to absorb their environment so completely, so effortlessly, fades as they grow older.

There is an almost exponential decline in brain plasticity influenced by experience in the first few years of life, and

it is remarkable that Montessori understood this without the assistance of MRI scanners and double-blind psychological experiments. For those familiar with Montessori's work it's just one more example of how "ahead of her time" she was. For new parents, it is hard scientific data demonstrating that the first few years of life are a vitally important period in a child's educational journey.

The amazing self-building absorbency of the young child's brain does not last forever, in fact it's fleeting. New parents should understand this and be ready to take advantage of their young child's short-lived superpower. Not only is this a great way to start children off on solid footing in their educational journey, but it is also a good way for new parents to understand a little more about why their young child's behavior can be so bizarre.

BIZARRE

The child climbs upstairs and on chairs. He does not climb on chairs in order to sit on them, but just for the sake of climbing. We may wonder why he should make such a great effort if he does not want to enjoy sitting in an arm-chair once he has got up and into it. But no, he climbs onto the seat of the chair, across the arms and down on the floor again. —Maria Montessori

Montessori thought that the key to understanding the sometimes irrational behavior of young children is understanding their emergent, absorbent minds. Observing children from this new point of view, she came to believe that the brains of young children operate very differently from adult brains when it comes to the relationship between emotions and learning.

She believed that learning through absorbency was an emotional experience for young children and that educators, parents, and other caregivers needed to be aware of this. As she wrote in *The Absorbent Mind*, "Children become like the things they love."



“...children are mainly using areas of the brain associated with emotion and physical movement when learning...”

Some educational philosophies tend to think of emotion as a roadblock or hinderance to the educational process. What we need to do, they might say, is get all of the feelings and the emotions out of the picture and then we can really get down to learning. But this is not how learning works in children, especially young children. That is not how their brains operate.

When adults and adolescents learn, they (of course) use many different parts of their brain in concert with each other, but they lean heavily on the prefrontal cortex. Because children have not developed a reliable prefrontal cortex, they learn using parts of their brain more closely connected to emotions, like the amygdala.

These brain scans show that children are mainly using areas of the brain associated with emotion and physical movement when learning and that this is a unique feature of the young child's brain.

New parents should be aware of this profound connection between emotion and learning in young children and should consider it as they select a school, prepare their home environment, or give lessons. To help new parents understand Montessori's absorbent mind is to help them understand their child more fully, to see things through their eyes. And it may also help them see just how beautiful the minds of young children are.

BEAUTIFUL

The absorbent mind is beautiful. Montessori often compared it to the opening of a flower. And like a flower, it only flourishes in the right conditions, in the right environment. Helping new parents see the beauty in the sometimes strange behavior of their young children is not just a way to help them manage difficult situations more effectively. It's also a way to help them build a better relationship with their young child – long before they are able to use hand gestures or speak.

One specific way for parents to do this is to focus on what modern researchers call “serve and return” interactions. The idea is that young children and infants “serve” by showing interest in something, it may be an object, a facial expression or a vocalization. In response the adult “returns” by responding in a supportive or collaborative way. This kind of interaction places the child and their interests at the center of the learning environment and asks the adult caregiver to follow the child’s lead.

Of course, anyone familiar with Montessori and her work knows how similar this language is to language used in Montessori’s *Absorbent Mind*. She understood and identified the “serve-and-return” mechanic almost a hundred years before the phrase was coined. And she understood that this was not just a beautiful way to build relationships with young children but also an effective way to help them learn, to help them build themselves from the inside out.

What does all of this mean for new parents? How can they relate Montessori’s absorbent mind to their everyday lives? What are some practical takeaways from what we have learned?

TAKEAWAYS FOR NEW PARENTS

- You are your child’s first teacher. Your habits, vocabulary, mood, and interactions with others become part of the lesson you are giving them.
- Your child’s second teacher is the physical environment they spend their time in. Consider their amazing, absorbent mind as you set up their room, their play spaces, and your family living spaces. Think about the sights, sounds and smells that will surround them.
- Remember that for young children learning is often an emotional experience. It is also hard work. Take a moment to reflect on how hard they work each day to build themselves from the inside out.
- Take time to imagine things from your child’s point of view while you are in the physical spaces that surround

them. Go into their room and kneel down on the floor to see things through their eyes.

- As Montessori said, “follow the child.” Let their interests and their curiosities lead interactions as much as possible, especially with infants and young children. This is not just a great way to help them learn, it is a beautiful way build a balanced, healthy relationship. ■



Sandra Karnstadt began her professional journey in public education as an administrator before discovering her passion for the Montessori approach. She holds a bachelor’s degree in early childhood education and a master’s degree in educational administration. With over 30 years of experience in Montessori, Sandra has embraced a variety of roles, including assistant, guide, director, owner, teacher/parent educator, consultant, and head of schools. Currently, she owns three Montessori schools, serving a vibrant community of over 600 individuals—children, staff, and parents. In addition to her school leadership, Sandra is dedicated to adult education for both parents and teachers and works as an independent consultant, collaborating with other educational institutions.

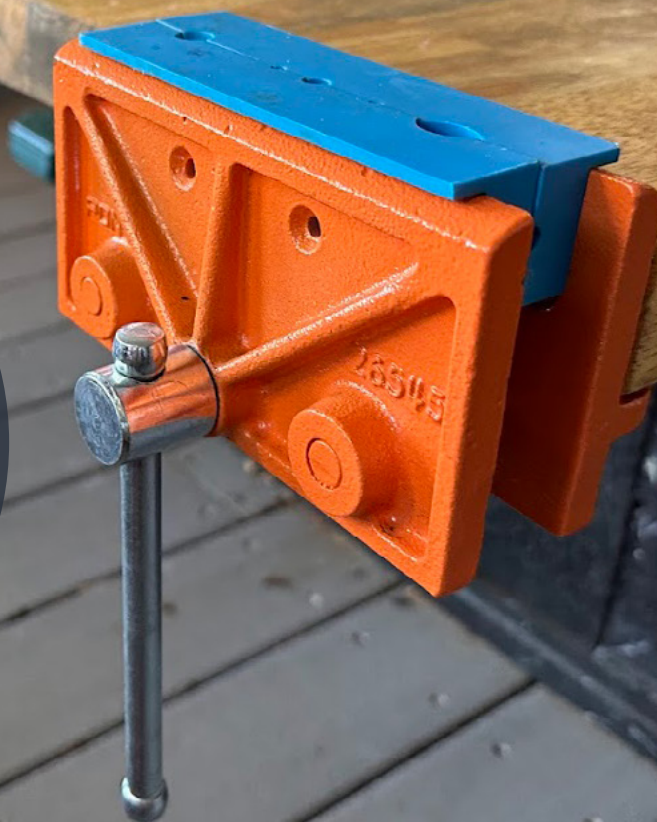


Joshua Dodds has spent more than a decade working with children of all ages both in traditional and nontraditional educational environments. He holds a Master of Liberal Arts from St. Edwards University and a Doctor of Liberal Studies from Southern Methodist University. Both in his academic life and in his vocational life, Joshua has focused on the intersection of Montessori philosophy and paleoanthropology but has also studied how Montessori principles can be incorporated into traditional educational environments. He is currently developing and field testing curriculum for talking about prehistory in preschool environments.

CRAFTING CONFIDENCE

A Montessori Woodworking
Program for Ages 3-6

by James Farwell



I teach this to my children at home, so why don't we offer it at our school?

In 2019, I became a first-time father to my now oldest son John. By three years old, it became clear that John was my shadow – he rarely was not found following me around our family's small farm as I maintained and fixed our property. By around four years old, he was able to use most non-power tools for woodworking and he clearly enjoyed working with wood. As building materials go, wood is in the sweet spot—it is hard enough to be used as a serious building material, but soft enough that hand tools can manipulate

it. By five years old, John was able to create woodworking projects on his own including building a rudimentary skateboard. It struck me how much my son loved woodworking and I decided that I wanted to offer it to all our students at our school, Montessori School of Fort Myers. In early 2024, I began the online research process to see what was kind of curriculum materials already out there for 3-6 year olds, and I came across the writings of author Pete Moorehouse at www.irresistible-learning.co.uk. I read his book¹ and I adapted his materials list to meet the needs of our school.²

The Basics

- **Safety:** As Pete Moorhouse outlines in his book, the main risk of injury for non-motorized woodworking tools is something flying into the eyes. This is easily solved by providing a basket of safety glasses that are required to be worn at all times while working in the woodworking area. We are very strict on that rule

Download my
customized list of
materials here.



and if a child is found not wearing them while in the woodworking area, they are asked to go inside and try again tomorrow. We also provide leather work gloves for sawing work. Our students have participated in this program daily for about a year and a half so far, and we have had zero serious injuries aside from some sore fingers from the hammering area.

- **Tool Storage:** The woodworking area is completely self-contained in a lockable folding shelf cabinet that can be closed when it's not directly attended by an adult. While it is possible to lock it, we have never once had a student try to open it without an adult present.
- **Worktables:** We attached 2" thick butcher's board from Lowe's to our recycled plastic outdoor picnic tables and applied tung oil to finish the wood. This thick surface makes it easier to hammer and otherwise be rough with

the materials as needed. The students enjoy having a surface that they are not afraid to damage—it is clearly a work area where you are free to make mistakes and get your hands dirty.

- **Clean Up:** On the side of the tool storage cabinet are several hooks where we hang a hand-held vacuum for saw dust clean up and magnetic stick for picking up dropped fasteners. We have no shortage of volunteers who want to use the fun clean up tools.
- **Hours of Operation:** The woodworking area is open every day during morning and/or afternoon work cycle. We have two primary classes with a total of five teachers. When one teacher goes outside with the children, she usually takes 5-10 students with her to maintain proper student to teacher ratios inside and outside.



The Scope and Sequence

I think of the woodworking area as checking off three separate areas of our scope and sequence: control of movement; practical life; and creative arts. Control of movement includes large-muscle group work during sawing, hammering, using the bit brace, etc. and fine-motor control is found when attaching fasteners and using the small hand tools. As a part of practical life, each of the big four goals is neatly checked off: order; coordination; concentration; and independence. The creative arts part of the program is reserved for our third-year students who engage in creating woodworking projects, which is a separate part of our woodworking program. These are the activities in approximate order that they are placed on the shelves from left to right:



- 1. Build vocabulary:** Three-part cards with photos of the actual tools available for use help young students build vocabulary to describe which items they are using.

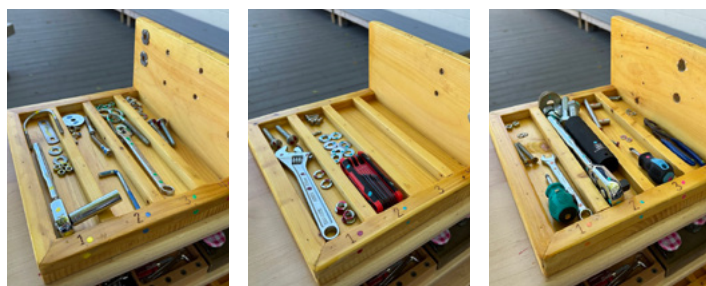


- 2. Introduction of fastener board:** Students start out using an introduction level fastener board, which offers

a variety of small fasteners and several drivers including a screw driver and an Allen wrench.



- 3. Hammering:** Students are given a variety of nail sizes starting with simple 3" nails and advancing in difficulty to smaller 1" nails that are harder to hold while hammering. Children are encouraged to pound the nails into a large stump where they can use the claw side of the hammer to remove them from the stump. The more advanced hammering work involves the children using F clamps to attach a piece of 2"x6" to the worktable and then using a ball peen hammer and a cat's paw to remove the nails.



- 4. The fastener board:** I created a homemade sequence of fastener boards that progress in difficulty. Tools progress from light to heavy, fasteners move from small to large, and that most important variable is that the fasteners board move from only requiring one hand to hold a tool to eventually both hands must use tools to complete the work. The most advanced fastener board is difficult even for our kindergartners.

- 5. Drilling:** Students start out with a bit brace that requires a large whole arm movement to drill, which is

not really found in the practical life area except for possibly stirring a large mixing bowl. The pistol grip drill is smaller and more difficult to control. Children use C and F clamps to secure the wood to the worktable.



6. Sawing: Sawing starts with a homemade material holder where children use a hacksaw (nearly impossible to cut yourself) and small pieces of cardboard. Sawing progresses to a stiff Japanese pull saw where students progress from cutting super soft balsa wood, to less soft basswood, and finally to the hardest southern yellow

pine. No hardwoods like oak are available to cut as they are too difficult for hand tools. The last saw is the flimsy European style handsaw which is the most difficult to control. Leather work gloves are placed in all sawing trays. Child uses a pencil, measuring tape, and speed square to measure ½" segments to saw off the wood.



7. Filing and sanding: This tray is good practice for the woodworking projects of our oldest students.



8. Attaching hardware: The most difficult work in the woodworking area involves children using an electric screwdriver and a variety of screws to attach various pieces of hardware to a piece of wood. It spins very slowly and is small enough for 3–6-year-old hands. Coat hangers, door hinges, door latches and more are rotated into the work tray for mounting.

Woodworking projects available for third year students

Our third-year students work with a parent volunteer once per week for an hour to make different woodworking projects that the children can take home. Last school year we made candy dispensers, folder holders, napkin holders,



people robots, stools, toolboxes, vehicles, wall art, and dinosaurs. This takes a lot of preparation work from our parent volunteer who we are very appreciative of her work!

Trusting our students

Watching my son John transform from my little shadow into a confident 5-year-old craftsman, hammering nails and shaping wood on our family farm, opened my eyes to something Maria Montessori wrote frequently about: children crave real work that challenges and empowers them. Bringing woodworking to our school isn't just about replicating that joy for our 3–6-year-olds. It is about trusting them to wield real tools, solve problems, and create useful objects with their own hands. Give children the tools and they will shape their own futures. ■

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¹<https://a.co/d/99EWqec>

²www.irresistible-learning.co.uk/wp-content/uploads/2018/01/Woodwork-equipment-list-and-suppliers-March-2018.pdf



James Farwell is the Head of School of the Montessori School of Ft. Myers, Florida. He grew up in Woodbury, MN attending several Montessori schools throughout childhood including Woodbury Montessori, Nokomis Montessori School, J.J. Hill Montessori, and Valley Crossing Community School. As a lifelong learner and teacher, Mr. James has served as a Sunday school teacher, taught snowboarding lessons, assistant taught at the University of Florida, has served as a guest speaker at Florida International University, and taught financial analysis courses. Mr. James enjoys finding ways to better serve students, families, and staff. In his free time, he enjoys working on the school facility, playing soccer, weightlifting, growing fruit trees, reading, and discussing self-improvement.



SCREEN-SMART *Summer*

Tips for Managing Tech Use and Wellness

by Cassi Mackey, M.Ed

Establish Clear Expectations & Consistency

- Create a family tech agreement outlining when, where, and how devices can be used.
- Be consistent with boundaries to help children develop healthy tech habits.

Model Healthy Tech Habits

- Demonstrate mindful use (e.g., turning off notifications, setting app limits).
- Reflect openly on tech choices to build awareness.
- Prioritize face-to-face interactions.

Encourage Outdoor & Offline Activities

- Balance screen time with daily outdoor play, exercise, or hands-on activities (e.g., reading, board games, or art projects).
- Set a goal for screen-free adventures (e.g., weekly nature walks, family outings, or DIY projects).

Use Tech as a Tool for Connection

- Encourage video calls with family and friends over passive scrolling.
- Explore co-learning opportunities, such as virtual museum tours, online courses, or interactive STEM projects.

Create Tech-Free Zones

- No devices at the dining table, to foster conversation.
- Keep bedrooms screen-free for better sleep. Use a central charging station to limit late-night use.

Set Time Limits

- Establish screen-free hours and one tech-free evening per week.
- Set clear time limits for device use.

Promote Purposeful Tech Use

- Teach digital citizenship and responsible online behavior.
- Encourage creation over consumption (e.g., coding, digital art, podcasting).

Prioritize Digital Well-Being & Safety

- Discuss cyberbullying, misinformation, and privacy.
- Foster critical thinking about social media.
- Emphasize the importance of taking breaks.

Why Chores Matter

What the Research Says about Children and Responsibility

by Tim Seldin, President,
The Montessori Foundation

Inspired by the article "Should Kids Do Chores?" by Megha Satyanarayana, Scientific American (March 2024)

If your child has ever flopped dramatically onto the floor, groaning that their legs “don’t work” when you ask them to sweep up crumbs or unload the dishwasher, you’re not alone. Chores often come with eye rolls, sighs, and protests. “None of my friends have to do this!” may sound familiar in your home too.

In Montessori-inspired homes, we ask children to contribute to household chores because we know it builds something deeper than clean dishes or tidy floors.

A recent *Scientific American* article by Megha Satyanarayana explores this topic in a refreshingly down-to-earth way. Drawing from research by Dr. Rebecca Scharf and Dr. Elizabeth White at the University of Virginia, the article highlights what many Montessorians have observed for years: children who do chores feel more confident, more capable, and even happier.

The researchers analyzed a large national dataset that tracked children from kindergarten through third grade. They found that children who regularly had chores—things like helping with laundry, setting the table, or tidy-

ing up—were more likely to describe themselves as good at school, socially skilled, and confident in their abilities. These weren’t massive differences, but they were consistent and meaningful.



What’s especially interesting is that this sense of confidence wasn’t limited to doing tasks at home. It seemed to spill over into how children viewed their academic skills and peer relationships. Children who contributed at home were more likely to say things like, “I am good at math,” or “I am good at science.” That sense of agency—that “I-can-do-things” mindset—is something we try to cultivate in every Montessori classroom from toddlerhood onward.

MAKING CHORES MORE MEANINGFUL

(and Age-Appropriate)

If you'd like to encourage your child to take on more responsibility at home, here are a few Montessori-informed tips to help make chores feel more engaging and developmentally appropriate:

Toddlers (18 months–3 years):

- ☑ Keep tools child-sized: a small broom, a spray bottle with water, or a low hook for a dustpan.
- ☑ Involve them in real work: wiping spills, putting napkins on the table, feeding pets.
- ☑ Use slow, simple demonstrations—then step back and let them try.

Preschoolers (3–6 years)

- ☑ Invite them to help with food prep: slicing bananas with a child-safe knife, stirring batter, peeling eggs.
- ☑ Let them sort laundry, match socks, and fold small items like washcloths.
- ☑ Make cleanup part of the routine by keeping everything accessible and labeled.

Elementary (6–12 years):

- ☑ Encourage daily contributions: sweeping floors, setting the table, making their bed.
- ☑ Let them rotate jobs and take ownership—perhaps even make a simple “family job chart.”
- ☑ Involve them in planning meals or shopping lists to deepen the sense of collaboration.

Adolescents (12+ years):

- ☑ Give them more autonomy and leadership: cooking full meals, organizing a closet, managing their own laundry.
- ☑ Invite them to contribute to larger family tasks like gardening, budgeting, or planning a family trip.
- ☑ Ask for their ideas on how to make household systems more efficient—this builds initiative and problem-solving.

They're not just "chores," they are purposeful, real-life tasks that allow children to care for themselves, others, and their environment.

In Montessori, we call these activities Practical Life. They're not just "chores"—they are purposeful, real-life tasks that allow children to care for themselves, others, and their environment. Pouring water, polishing shoes, scrubbing tables, folding laundry—these are not busywork. They're foundational experiences that support executive functioning, coordination, independence, and a deep sense of dignity and contribution.

The article also touched on something I loved: the idea of social negotiation. Children may try to bargain their way out of doing chores—"Can I read one more chapter first?" or "What if I take out the trash and wipe the counters, but not sweep?" That back-and-forth is actually a vital life skill. It teaches communication, empathy, and compromise. And it mirrors the kinds of collaborative problem-solving we nurture in Montessori classrooms every day.

So yes, children may grumble. They may protest. But beneath the moans and groans, they are learning that their actions matter—that they are needed members of a family or a classroom. Over time, this builds an internal sense of purpose and belonging that no worksheet or reward chart can replicate.

As Satyanarayana writes, the benefit of chores isn't just about learning how to clean up. It's about giving children the experience of contributing meaningfully to the world around them. A gift that will last far beyond childhood.

Above all, remember that children want to feel capable. When we include them in the real work of daily life, we give them the tools to believe in themselves—and to become confident, caring contributors to the world around them. ■



Tim Seldin is President of the Montessori Foundation. His more than 40 years of experience in Montessori education includes 22 years as Headmaster of the Barrie School in Silver Spring, Maryland, his *alma mater* from toddler through high school graduation. Tim was Co-Founder and Director of the Institute for Advanced Montessori Studies and the Center for Guided Montessori Studies. He earned a B.A. in History and Philosophy from Georgetown University, an M.Ed. in Educational Administration and Supervision from The American University, and his Montessori certification from the American Montessori Society.

Tim is the author of several books on Montessori Education, including *How to Raise An Amazing Child*, and *The World in the Palm of Her Hand*. Look for his newest book, *Montessori for Every Family*, co-authored with Lorna McGrath.

A Montessori Summer for the Whole Child

by Montessori Foundation Staff

When you think back to your own childhood summers, what do you remember? Maybe it was running through the sprinkler in the backyard, camping under the stars, building something in the garage with your grandparent, or lazily flipping through comic books on a rainy day. Summer has always held a special place in our collective memory—a time of exploration, freedom, and growth.

But today's parents face a dilemma: How do we help our children enjoy a carefree, memory-making summer and keep their minds and spirits engaged? For Montessori families, the answer isn't found in rigid schedules or academic drills. It's found in rhythm, choice, and meaningful experiences.

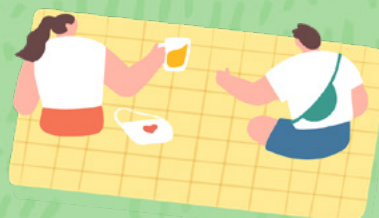
As Montessori educators often say, "There is no such thing as doing nothing." Even a lazy afternoon can be rich in development—if we see it through a Montessori lens.

Start with Observation, Not Obligation

Too often, parents feel pressure to fill every hour of summer with "something educational" to prevent the so-called "summer slide." But what if we started by observing our children—listening to what excites them, what they wonder about, what they return to again and again?

"I used to plan out every week with color-coded calendars," laughs Sara, a mother of two Montessori students, ages 6 and 9. "But last summer, I started by asking them what they were curious about. My son wanted to build a treehouse. My daughter was into bugs. That set the tone for our whole summer."

In Montessori, observation is a powerful tool. Instead of filling summer with obligations, consider co-creating it with your child. Ask: What do you want to learn, explore, or make this summer?



Embrace the Five “-Cations”

The slideshow “Summer Slides to Summer Strides” introduces five playful categories of summer experience: Vacation, Staycation, Education, Playcation, and Campcation. You don’t need to choose just one. The magic happens in the mix.



Vacation doesn’t have to mean a week at the beach (though that’s lovely too). It can be a family road

trip, a weekend camping trip, or just a change of scenery. What matters most is rhythm—keeping some consistency in meals, bedtime, and daily routines, especially for younger children.

Staycations can be full of local adventure. Let your elementary-age child plan a family outing—give them a small budget, a map, and a few guidelines. “My daughter planned a whole ‘Day in Italy’ last summer,” says Marcus, a Montessori dad in Ohio. “We went to an Italian bakery, made homemade pasta, and watched an old Italian movie with subtitles. It was amazing.”

Education in summer should feel joyful, not obligatory. Think curiosity, not curriculum. Read a chapter book

together as a family, visit a museum with a sketchpad in hand, or start a nature journal in your own backyard. A project-based approach is best—children retain more when they’re creating, not just consuming.

Playcation might be the most important of all. Montessori children thrive on open-ended, imaginative play. Set up a loose parts play area with recycled materials and let their creativity soar. Resist the urge to supervise too closely. As Maria Montessori reminded us, “Play is the work of the child.”

Campcation can offer social opportunities and exposure to new interests. But be choosy. Some camps can be overstimulating or overly structured. Look for ones that match your child’s temperament and interests—perhaps a nature camp, theater workshop, or STEM lab. And don’t forget: downtime is essential. Balance busy days with slow mornings or quiet evenings.

Education in summer should feel joyful, not obligatory. Think curiosity, not curriculum.

The Power of Purposeful Freedom

Montessori elementary children, in particular, are hungry for agency. They’re entering a phase where their imagination blooms, and their desire to contribute to the world expands.

Give them space to lead. Let them help plan meals, take over a garden bed, or organize a lemonade fundraiser for a cause they care about. These aren’t just fun summer activities—they’re acts of responsibility, creativity, and compassion.

“One summer, my son built a ‘tiny library’ box with his grandfather,” says Lena, a Montessori mom in

California. “They stocked it with books, painted it, and installed it at the park. He checked on it every week and wrote a journal about the books that came and went. He felt like he was part of something bigger.”

That’s the kind of learning that doesn’t slide away—it becomes part of who they are.

Avoid the Over-Schedule Trap

Parents often feel a low-grade anxiety in summer: “Am I doing enough?” But the Montessori approach reminds us that being is just as valuable as doing.

Children need unstructured time to process their experiences, solve boredom on their own, and connect with the natural world. This doesn’t mean screens all day—it means rest, reflection, and relationship.

“I stopped filling every minute,” says James, a father of three Montessori kids. “We started having quiet mornings—no screens, no rush. My kids began making breakfast together and going outside to build forts. It was like they rediscovered each other.”

Let your summer have breath. Build in time for hammock reading, barefoot exploring, and aimless doodling. These moments are fertile soil for growth.

What to Skip This Summer

In the spirit of gentle guidance, here are a few things Montessori parents might not do this summer:

- Don’t panic about academic regression. Children who feel safe, curious, and connected will catch up—and often leap ahead—when given the right environment.
- Don’t rely on rewards and punishments to motivate summer learning. Instead, offer real-life purpose and choice.
- Don’t over-schedule to the point of exhaustion. Children need rest, and so do you.
- Don’t assume that “fun” means flashy. A walk in the woods, a conversation on the porch, or a shared art project can be deeply joyful.

One Last Thought...

Summer can be a bridge—not a break—from your child’s growth. With a Montessori mindset, every season is a chance to support your child’s development not just academically, but emotionally, socially, and spiritually.

So whether you find yourself on a mountain trail, in your backyard garden, or curled up on the couch reading *Charlotte’s Web* together, remember: it’s not about preventing a slide. It’s about planting seeds for life. ■





Khalsa Montessori School

A 53-YEAR LEGACY OF PEACE, PURPOSE, AND COMMUNITY

by Karen Paxton

As the Head of School at Khalsa Montessori, I often get asked what makes our school so special — and why we've stood strong in the heart of downtown Phoenix, Arizona for more than 53 years. It's a question I love to answer because our story is unlike any other.

Khalsa is more than a school. We're a community, a peaceful learning environment, and a place where children are respected as individuals. We serve children from 18 months through 6th grade, with three cozy campuses — toddler,

primary, and elementary — all within walking distance of each other right here in downtown Phoenix.

What's especially unique is that we're a public charter school starting at kindergarten, which means we're tuition-free for families from that point on. Our toddler and preschool programs are private because Arizona doesn't fund early childhood education the way some other states do. Even kindergarten in Arizona is only funded for 2.5 hours a day, so we supplement that with a strong private





Khalsa Primary School Campus



morning program to give children a full and meaningful Montessori experience.

At Khalsa, Montessori isn't just a method — it's a way of being. We focus on educating the whole child, which includes daily practices like yoga, mindfulness, and conflict resolution. We guide children to find peace within themselves so they can bring peace to their relationships and their world. Service to others is woven into our curriculum, from simple acts of kindness to larger community projects. These aren't just add-ons — they're part of who we are.

I'm often moved by the sense of calm and purpose you feel when you walk into one of our classrooms. There's a quiet energy — children are engaged, focused, and genuinely

happy to be here. We don't rush childhood. We honor each child's developmental journey and offer them the space and support to grow into capable, compassionate human beings.

We currently serve about 180 children across all three campuses, and because we're intentionally small, we really get to know our students and their families. This sense of connection — of truly seeing and valuing each child — is what I believe keeps families with us year after year.

When you choose Khalsa, you're choosing a school with deep roots and a clear mission. You're choosing a place where peace, service, and community aren't just taught — they're lived every day. And you're choosing a team of educators who believe in your child's potential not just academically, but as a person with gifts to share with the world.

If you're looking for something different — something grounded, joyful, and full of heart — I invite you to come visit. Let us show you what Montessori can look like when it's practiced with intention, integrity, and love for over five decades. ■

FORGED IN BOREDOM

Skills for a Lifetime

by Cassi Mackey, M.Ed

I grew up in New Mexico, The Land of Enchantment, where the sun-drenched mountains and piñon tree-scented air weren't just part of a place on a map; it was a boundless playground for my childhood imagination. Santa Fe became a realm where canyons were castles, pine needles were currency, and the rustling wind whispered secrets only a child could understand. It was here, amidst the rugged beauty and hidden arroyos, that my soul was nourished, and my creative spirit took flight, fueled by the limitless possibilities found in the simple act of being present in nature's embrace. Being in nature seemed to encourage a certain kind of "enchanted boredom," a state where the

absence of manufactured stimulation allowed the land to fill the quiet with its own magic.

It was in these moments, when the stillness of the mountain invited introspection, that the true power of unscripted play and self-directed discovery took root, transforming simple boredom into a portal to endless imaginative adventures. For my sister and I, our parents placed the onus of boredom squarely on our shoulders, encouraging us to be independent in our choices and to rely on the boundless landscapes of our imaginations. If we weren't outside, forging new worlds from sticks and stones, we were inside,

creating our own schoolhouse to teach imaginary students. And if neither of those pursuits captured our fancy, our noses were invariably buried in the pages of a book, each word a portal to another adventure.

This parenting approach, placing the “onus of boredom” on my sister and me, was incredibly beneficial for several key developmental reasons.



The Developmental Power of Boredom

Fostering Deep Independence

- By not constantly providing entertainment, my parents instilled a strong sense of self-reliance. We learned to generate our own fun, solve our own problems, and manage our own time. This independence translated into greater confidence and resourcefulness.

Cultivating Unbridled Creativity

- The freedom to create “new worlds” from available common objects nurtured our imaginations. We weren’t confined to pre-set narratives or structured play. We were actively building our own realities, fostering innovative thinking and problem solving.

Developing Strong Intrinsic Motivation

- Because we weren’t relying on external sources of en-

tertainment, we learned to find joy and satisfaction in our own creations and explorations. This developed a powerful sense of intrinsic motivation, where we pursued activities for their inherent enjoyment rather than external rewards.

Enhancing Problem-Solving and Resourcefulness

- Turning “found objects” into playthings required resourcefulness and creative problem-solving. We learned to see potential in the ordinary, to adapt to our surroundings, and to find solutions with limited resources.

Nurturing a Love of Learning

- The emphasis on reading not only expanded our knowledge but also fostered a lifelong love of learning. Books became portals to new worlds and ideas, sparking curiosity and a thirst for knowledge.

Promoting Emotional Regulation

- By navigating boredom, we cultivated the ability to embrace quiet and stillness, an essential skill for emotional regulation and resilience. These moments of downtime teach one to find contentment in solitude while providing valuable opportunities for self-reflection. Through this process, we deepened our self-awareness and got support for our emotional growth.

Building Cognitive Flexibility

- Jumping from outside imaginative play to inside imaginative play then to reading created a great deal of cognitive flexibility. Our minds were constantly adapting to new environments and challenges.

Promoting Resilience

- Navigating moments of boredom fostered resilience, equipping us with the ability to comfortably manage downtime.

Strengthening Sibling Bonds

- Playing together, my sister and I developed a strong bond; we learned to collaborate and navigate social interactions, which are crucial societal skills.

Embrace Boredom the Montessori Way

I recognize that my environment was something not available to all children, and I recognize how dramatically things have shifted since my own childhood, a time when open-ended afternoons and sprawling natural landscapes were the norm. Because we live in a world filled with digital distractions and packed schedules, boredom is often met with unease. Yet, within the Montessori philosophy, boredom isn't a problem to be solved, but rather an opportunity for growth. By embracing the Montessori approach, we can guide our children towards self-directed learning and cultivate their innate creativity during moments of "boredom."



Create a "Boredom-Friendly" Environment

■ Strategic Tech Boundaries

- Establish clear expectations and consistency
- Model healthy tech habits

- Encourage outdoor and offline activities

- Use tech as a tool for connection

- Create tech-free zones

- Set time limits

- Promote purposeful tech use

- Prioritize digital well-being and safety

■ Provide Open-Ended Materials: Stocking your home with materials that encourage creativity and exploration:

- Art supplies (paper, crayons, paint, clay)

- Building blocks, LEGO™ bricks, or other construction toys

- Dress-up clothes and props

- Natural objects (sticks, stones, leaves)

- Books, books, books

- More complex materials: model kits, science experiment kits, woodworking tools (with supervision), advanced art supplies, musical instruments

- Materials for "maker" activities: electronic components, recycled materials for building projects, sewing supplies

■ Organize and Access. Make sure these materials are easily accessible to your child; a messy but organized space is better than a tidy but inaccessible one:

- Encourage children to organize their own spaces and materials. This fosters a sense of ownership and responsibility.



...within the Montessori philosophy, boredom isn't a problem to be solved, but rather an opportunity for growth.

- Help them create dedicated spaces for their hobbies and interests.
- **Rotate Toys:** keep things interesting by rotating toys and materials; this prevents them from becoming stale.
- **Rotating “Challenges”:** Instead of simply rotating toys, introduce new challenges or projects: “This week, try to build a working robot,” or “Learn a new song on the piano.”
- **Encourage Independent Pursuits:** Respect their need for solitude and allow them to pursue their own interests without constant supervision. Recognize that their definition of “boredom” might be different from yours.
- **Patience Is Key:** It may take time for your child to adjust to unstructured time. Be patient and consistent.
- **Celebrate Their Creativity:** Acknowledge your child’s creative efforts, even if they seem simple.

Trust the Process of Growth and Discovery

- **Coaching, Not Rescuing:** Move from offering direct suggestions to asking open-ended questions: “What are some things you could do?” or “What resources do you have available?” Act as a coach, helping them brainstorm and problem-solve.
- **Embrace the Silence:** Don’t feel pressured to fill every moment with noise and activity. Allow for quiet time and downtime.
- **Focus on the Process, Not the Product:** Encourage your child to enjoy the process of creating and exploring, rather than focusing on the end result.
- **Model Lifelong Learning:** Share your own hobbies and interests, demonstrating that learning and exploration are lifelong pursuits. Discuss your own strategies for managing downtime and finding creative outlets.
- **Model Healthy Boredom:** Show your child that it’s okay to have quiet moments. Read a book, work on a hobby, or simply relax without distractions.



- **Facilitate, Don't Dictate:** Help them to access resources, like the library or a local class, but allow them to make the ultimate choice on their activities.
- **Trust Their Abilities:** Believe that your child is capable of finding their own solutions and entertaining themselves.
- **Don't Fear the Mess:** Creative exploration can be messy. Embrace it! Provide designated spaces for messy play and give lessons to your children how to clean up afterward.

Practical Strategies

- **Schedule "Unstructured Time":** Build periods of free time into your child's daily routine. This allows them to practice self-directed play.
- **Project-Based "Unstructured Time":** Encourage long-term projects that require planning and problem-solving: writing a novel, building a website, creating a stop-motion animation.
- **Encourage Outdoor Play:** Send your child outside to explore nature. Even a small backyard can provide endless opportunities for adventure.
- **Community Exploration:** Encourage them to explore their community: visit museums, libraries, parks, or

attend local events. Facilitate opportunities for volunteering or participating in community projects.

- **Collaborative Challenges:** Set up challenges that require collaboration between siblings or friends.
- **Embrace Practical Life:** Simple chores can be surprisingly engaging. Have them help with sorting laundry, setting the table, or watering plants.
- **Promote Reading:** Reading fosters imagination and expands knowledge. Keep a variety of age-appropriate books available.



- **Advanced Reading and Research:** Encourage them to explore non-fiction topics that pique their interest. Introduce them to research skills and encourage them to use libraries and online resources responsibly.
- **Create "Boredom Buster" Jars:** Fill jars with slips of paper containing simple activities (e.g., "draw a picture," "build a tower," "go outside"). When boredom strikes, your child can choose an activity from the jar.
- **Create "Challenge Jars" with Increased Complexity:** Instead of simple activities, the jars could contain challenges like "write a short play," "design a board game," or "conduct a science experiment."

- **Debate and Discussion:** Engage them in congenial discussions about appropriate current events, ethical dilemmas, or philosophical questions.
- **Encourage Imaginary Play:** Supply props and costumes that help them create their own stories and games.

Boredom's Enduring Gifts

Just as the sun-drenched mountains of Santa Fe once nurtured my own childhood imagination, fostering independence and resourcefulness through the boundless landscapes of unstructured play, we can provide our elementary children with the same fertile ground for growth. By thoughtfully crafting their environments, shifting our parental mindsets, and implementing age-appropriate strategies, we invite them to embrace the power of boredom. This isn't about simply filling time, but about cultivating the vital skills of creativity, problem-solving, and self-reliance, ensuring they are well-equipped to navigate

the complexities of their world, just as we navigated the canyons and arroyos of our own childhood adventures. ■



Cassi Mackey, M.Ed. is passionate about helping communities create identity-safe spaces, where people are encouraged to make changes to improve relationships.

Cassi has been in the Montessori field for 30 years as a teacher and school leader. She is currently an American Montessori Society (AMS) School Accreditation Commissioner, Instructional Guide for CGMS Leadership Certification and a trainer for the AMI Administrator certification course. She is certified as an Association Montessori Internationale (AMI) School Administrator and has completed the AMS Anti-bias Anti-racist certification course. She consults with and provides advice to Montessori communities that are intent on generating positive and lasting change.

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Why Stay for Kindergarten

by Cathie Perolman

DEAR CATHIE—

HOW IMPORTANT IS IT TO KEEP MY CHILD IN THE MONTESSORI CLASS THROUGH THE KINDERGARTEN YEAR? AFTER ALL SHE WILL HAVE TO TRANSITION TO HER NEIGHBORHOOD SCHOOL AT SOME POINT. ISN'T IT BEST THAT SHE DO IT WHEN ALL OF THE CHILDREN ARE ENTERING THE LOCAL ELEMENTARY SCHOOL? IF WE DON'T TRANSITION AT KINDERGARTEN, HOW WILL IT BE ANY DIFFERENT AT FIRST GRADE?

—A PRAGMATIC DAD

Dear Dad,

I think you are raising an issue that many parents consider. The short answer is that the best time to transition to traditional school is after the Kindergarten year. It is best to complete the three-year cycle in the Montessori 3-6 Program.

The public or non-Montessori Kindergarten teacher meets each child as an unknown entity. She has to begin from scratch learning about what your child knows, how your child behaves, how your child learns, and what your child finds interesting and motivating. Not only does the teacher need to learn about your child but every other child in the class as well. The teacher does this at the same time as they are establishing the school and classroom routines, as well as keeping all the children busy by giving them “activities” and “work” that keeps the entire class busy regardless of their knowledge and skill level. These activities are probably not interesting, fun or challenging to children who already read and have mastery of the basics of academics. These are probably even less enticing for a child

who has been academically challenged in a Montessori environment. It takes a teacher a significant amount of time to figure out the knowledge basis of each child in the class and by the time this has occurred, many weeks will have passed and your child will have lost that learning opportunity and will have begun to form an opinion of this new school.

Contrast this with the beginning of Kindergarten in a Montessori school. When your child enters Kindergarten in the Montessori school, her guide knows all about them. The teacher knows what your child has mastered, what they find challenging and what they enjoy. From the first day of their kindergarten year, your child's learning progresses according to their own pace in all aspects of the curriculum. Your child is viewed as a leader by all members of the community and enters the classroom with joy and confidence. They choose work that they enjoy!

The local traditional Kindergarten also teaches to the average child in the class. She is responsible to make sure that

each child masters the learning objectives of the local school district and often the Common Core. While there may be some grouping made for advanced children, who are able to learn more than that language or math, much of the day will be spent learning with the class in whole groups mastering those basic skills. Children have little chance to follow their passions and learn about the things that interest them.

In the Montessori Kindergarten, children progress at their own pace in all aspects of the curriculum. Once a child has mastered the basic skills of the kindergarten level, they move past that level seamlessly and are introduced to more challenging work in that area. If a child shows interest in a subject or an area, they are introduced to work in that area on their instructional level. Thus, each child is constantly challenged based on their individual level of functioning.

By first grade in local elementary schools, the children have been grouped academically and all children are familiar with the basics of the school routine and the

expectations of school. Now your child can slide into the class, be placed into an instructional group that is appropriate for their functioning and lose much less time academically. There will definitely be a transition. Traditional schools function much differently than Montessori schools and that is important to discuss with your child so she will be prepared for the change.

We feel that the third year in Primary is well worth the time and money! Parents often tell us that it is the most worthwhile year their child has spent with us and children look back on it with the most joy and fondness! It lets your child have the chance to be the leader in the classroom and give back to the classroom that gave so much to her when she was three and four years old. ■



Cathie Perolman has been involved in Montessori education for over 40 years. Cathie has worked in the classroom as a 3-6 assistant; a classroom teacher; a level leader; a teacher trainer; and a college professor. She currently spends her time mentoring teachers, conducting workshops for teachers and administrators; and writing for her blog and for magazines. She also serves as a consultant for schools and as a school validator for the Montessori Schools of Maryland. Cathie is the creator of the *Color Coded Sound Games* and the *Rainbow Reading System* as well as other reading and cosmic printable materials to enhance classrooms. Find them at cathieperolman.com.



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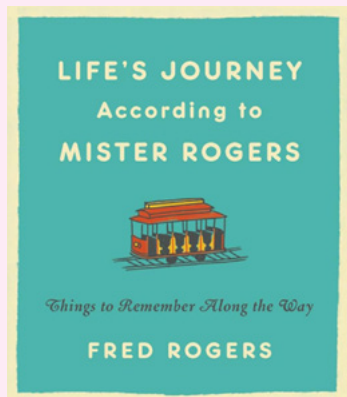
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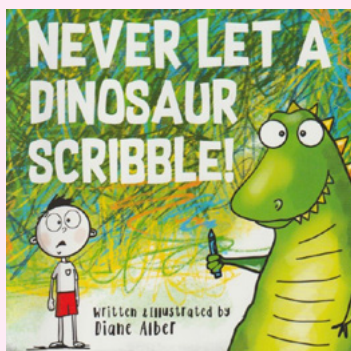
Life's Journeys According to Mister Rogers

Written by Fred Rogers

As many others have, I have found this man, Fred Rogers, to be an inspiration and a source of strength. In these turbulent times, so many of us are searching for a path to a life that is meaningful, honest, caring, and respectful for ourselves and our children. The words in this book resonate with those ideals. It is one of those books that I love because I can open it up to any page, on any day and the words will be just right to move me closer to my best self.

In Montessori we seek to prepare children for life, to see themselves as important, beautiful, and loved, and to know that it is ok to be "just the way they are."

I think that Fred Rogers would agree that when we are involved in children's lives we should keep this idea in mind: "Prepare the path for the child, not the child for the path." (unknown author) I suggest that you find Fred's book for yourself and read from it each day or whenever you choose to discover yourself again. Fill your cup so that you can be the best person you can be for children and others in your life's journey.

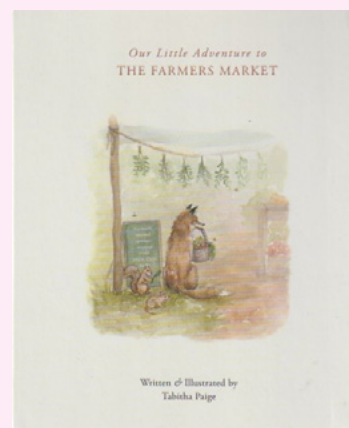


NEVER LET A DINOSAUR SCRIBBLE!

Written & Illustrated by Diane Alber

To be an artist one must start with the sense of freedom to imagine and create. And sometimes it starts with just a scribble and then it grows and develops into something amazing! That's the essence of this little story. Children who are artistically inclined

and some who are not yet so inclined will thoroughly enjoy this book (especially if they love dinosaurs!). Children from four years old and on into the elementary years will benefit from the permission it gives to being imaginative and creative.



Our Little Adventure to THE FARMERS MARKET

Written & Illustrated by Tabitha Paige

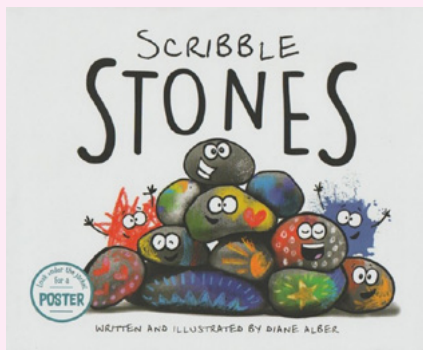
This wonderful board book is reminiscent of Beatrix Potter's work. The illustrations are realistic and detailed with all the animals. They are done in beautiful watercolors. Much like work Ms. Paige has her animals doing human things like speaking to each, shopping for food, and preparing a meal for a friend. If I were a teacher, parent, or caregiver, I would be asking the children things like, "Do animals

really go shopping?" and we would laugh and say, "Noooo. That's just silly or imaginary."

The content is written in rhyme. Young children love that and soon learn to join in with the rhyming word. The book contains some very good vocabulary, and it is very well depicted for the children to learn from. For example: kale may be a new type of vegetable for children. There is a very nice illustration of kale for them to see.

At the end of the book there are two pages devoted to the vocabulary with the words and pictures in isolation. This makes it easy for little ones to distinguish between each of the new words and what they look like. The last page of the book has three learning activities to try with children.

Children from 18 months through 5 years old will enjoy this book.



Scribble Stones

Written & Illustrated by Diane Alber

I thought I'd take a look at another one of Ms. Alber's books. This one is similar to "Never Let a Dinosaur Scribble!" in that it is about stones and scribbles. The difference is that in this book the content rhymes and the idea is that art makes people happy anywhere in the world.

So, the premise is that with stone art, one person can start to paint a stone and then give it to another person who

can add a little of their art to it. Once that is done, the stone can be given to a third person and their art can be added to the stone. When this series of giving events happens, they all can share the happiness that stone art brings.

Siblings, classmates, and other groups of children will enjoy this art activity. They can make the painted stones for giving to each other, to give to others on special occasions, to hospitals to be given to patients to cheer them, and more. For more information about art and creativity you can go to www.dianealber.com.

A fun surprise is that on the backside of the book's dust jacket there is a poster about the Stone Art give away game. Spread the happiness!



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